

The Introductory Word and the Day of Jehovah

Scripture Reading: Joel 1:1, 15; 2:1, 11, 31; 3:14

The book of Joel is short, but it is excellent, wonderful, and mysterious. In this message we will first give an introductory word and then consider the matter of the day of Jehovah, an important subject in the prophecy of the Bible.

I. The introductory word

A. The meaning of the name Joel

In Hebrew the name Joel means “Jehovah is God.”

B. The time of Joel’s ministry

The time of Joel’s ministry was about 800 B.C., probably after the prophet Elisha.

C. The object of Joel’s ministry

The object of Joel’s ministry was the southern kingdom of Judah.

D. The place of Joel’s ministry

The place of Joel’s ministry was also Judah.

E. The subject

The subject of the book of Joel is the devastation of the human government on Israel in four stages and the destruction of Christ over the devastators and His reign among Israel in the restoration (Rev. 20:4, 6; Matt. 19:28).

F. The central thought

The central thought of Joel is that the nations, as the locusts, devastate Israel consecutively in four empires, from Nebuchadnezzar, the first king of Babylon, to Antichrist, the last Caesar of Rome; they will be overcome and terminated by Christ, who will set up the kingdom and reign among the saved Israel in the age of restoration. The four empires that devastate Israel and that will be overcome and terminated by Christ are the Babylonian Empire, the Medo-Persian Empire, the Macedonian-Grecian Empire, and the Roman Empire. These four empires are signified by the great human image in Daniel 2, an image that will be destroyed by Christ as the stone cut out without hands (vv. 34-35). Actually, this stone signifies not merely the individual Christ but also the corporate Christ. The corporate Christ will come as a stone cut out without hands and will smite the human government into pieces.

G. The revelation concerning Christ

1. In His coming with His overcomers as the mighty ones to defeat Antichrist and his army

In the book of Joel Christ is revealed in His coming with His overcomers as the mighty ones to defeat Antichrist and his army (Joel 3:11).

2. In His judgment of the nations

In this book Christ is revealed also in His judgment of the nations (3:2a, 12, 14). This is the judgment of the living (Matt. 25:31-46; Acts 10:42; 17:31). Acts 10:42 tells us that Christ is the One who has been designated by God to be the Judge of the living and the dead, and 17:31 says that God “has set a day in which He is to judge the world in righteousness by the man whom He has designated.” Christ will judge the living just before the millennium and He will judge the dead after the millennium.

3. In His dwelling in the holy mountain of Zion within Jerusalem to reign among Israel

Finally, in Joel Christ is revealed in His dwelling in the holy mountain of Zion within Jerusalem to reign among Israel to be their God, their shelter, and their stronghold (Joel 3:16-17, 21b).

H. The sections

The book of Joel has five sections: the introduction (1:1), the plague of the locusts (1:2—2:11), the turn of Jehovah to His elect, Israel (2:12-32), the judgment of Christ upon the nations (3:1-15), and the victory of Christ over the nations and His reign among Israel (3:11, 16-21).

II. The day of Jehovah

The book of Joel speaks of the day of Jehovah (1:15; 2:1, 11, 31; 3:14).

A. The day of Jehovah in Joel being the day of the Lord in the New Testament

The day of Jehovah in the book of Joel is the day of the Lord in the New Testament (2 Pet. 3:10).

B. The Lord’s judgment for His governmental dealing

In expressions such as “the day of Jehovah” and “the day of the Lord” the word “day” is used mainly in the sense of the Lord’s judgment for His governmental dealing (Ezek. 13:5; 30:3; Zeph. 1:8-9).

C. The day of the Lord being the day in which the Lord judges

Before the Lord comes, it is “man’s day,” in which man judges (1 Cor. 4:3-5). Man will continue to judge until the Lord comes. After the Lord comes, it will be “the day of the Lord,” in which the Lord judges. Man’s day of judgment is the present age. This is in contrast to the Lord’s day, which is the coming age, the kingdom age, in which the judgment will be the Lord’s judgment. Today in the day of man, everyone is a judge. Even children judge their parents, and students judge their teachers. But in the day of the Lord, the Lord will stop all human judging and will give the final word.

D. The final day of Jehovah (the Lord) beginning at the sixth seal and ending at the judgment of the great white throne

The final day of Jehovah (the Lord) will begin at the sixth seal (Rev. 6:12-17), end at the judgment of the great white throne (Rev. 20:11-15), and comprise various calamities, plagues, and woes for the Lord’s punishing judgments and governmental dealings upon the heavens, the sun, the moon, the stars, the earth, men, Satan, and the demons to clear up the earth and the entire universe, for the new heaven and new earth (Rev. 21:1) to come for His eternal kingdom. The time from the sixth seal to the beginning of the thousand-year kingdom will be a little more than three and a half years. That will be the time mainly of the great tribulation. The judgment of the great white throne will take place after the thousand-year kingdom. Thus, the day of the Lord will last for about one thousand three and a half years.

Let us now briefly consider the calamities, plagues, and woes which the day of the Lord will comprise.

1. The natural calamities of the sixth seal

First, there will be the natural calamities of the sixth seal upon the sun, the moon, the stars, the heavens, and the earth.

2. The severer calamities of the first four trumpets

Revelation 8:7-12 speaks of the severer calamities of the first four trumpets upon the earth, the sea, the rivers, and the sun, moon, and stars. Actually, the calamities of the sixth seal and the first four trumpets are a cluster related to the judgment of the universe.

3. The first woe, the fifth trumpet

The first woe, the fifth trumpet, will be by the locusts from the abyss under Antichrist as their king, who will also come out from the abyss (Rev. 9:1-11).

4. The second woe, the sixth trumpet

The second woe, the sixth trumpet, will be by the four angels released from the Euphrates with the two hundred million horsemen (Rev. 9:12-19).

5. The third woe, the seventh trumpet

The third woe, the seventh trumpet, will be composed of the seven bowls (Rev. 11:14-15a; 15:1, 5-8; 16:1).

a. The evil and malignant sore of the first bowl

The evil and malignant sore of the first bowl will be upon the men who have the mark of the beast and worship his image (Rev. 16:2).

b. In the second bowl the sea becoming blood like that of a dead man

In the second bowl the sea will become blood like that of a dead man, and every living soul that is in the sea will die (Rev. 16:3).

c. In the third bowl the rivers and springs becoming blood

In the third bowl the rivers and springs will become blood to be the drink of those who pour out the blood of the saints and the prophets (Rev. 16:4-7).

d. In the fourth bowl the sun burning men with fire

In the fourth bowl the sun will burn men with fire (Rev. 16:8-9).

e. In the fifth bowl the kingdom of Antichrist becoming darkened

In the fifth bowl the kingdom of Antichrist will become darkened, and people will gnaw their tongues for pain and will blaspheme the God of heaven for their pains and sores (Rev. 16:10-11).

f. In the sixth bowl there being the war of Armageddon

In the sixth bowl there will be the war of Armageddon, in which Antichrist and his armies will fight against Christ with His overcomers. Christ will destroy Antichrist and all his evil armies, and Antichrist and the false prophet will be cast into the lake of fire (Rev. 16:12-16; 17:14; 19:19-21). In Revelation 14:17-20 Christ's defeating Antichrist and all his evil armies is likened to His treading of the great winepress of the fury of God.

g. The unprecedented earthquake of the seventh bowl

In the seventh bowl there will be an unprecedented earthquake. The great city of Jerusalem will be divided into three parts, the cities of the nations will fall, and political Babylon will be destroyed under God's wrath. Every island will flee, and the mountains will disappear. Furthermore, great hail will come out of heaven upon men (Rev. 16:17-21).

6. All the calamities, plagues, and woes from the sixth seal to the seventh bowl constituting the great tribulation, the hour of trial

All the calamities, plagues, and woes from the sixth seal to the seventh bowl constitute the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21), the hour of trial to try all the people who dwell on the earth (Rev. 3:10). The great tribulation will last for three and a half years (Rev. 11:2; 12:6, 12:14; 13:5).

a. The religious Babylon the Great being destroyed

Probably at the beginning of the great tribulation, the religious Babylon the Great, the Roman Catholic Church, will be destroyed by Antichrist (Rev. 14:8; 17:16). At the end of the great tribulation, the political Babylon the Great, the revived Roman Empire, will be destroyed by the Lord.

b. The two witnesses

In the great tribulation the two witnesses will spit fire out of their mouth to devour their enemies, will shut up the heavens from raining, will have authority to turn the waters into blood, and will smite the earth with every plague (Rev. 11:3-6).

c. Antichrist blaspheming God and making war with the saints and overcoming them

In the three and a half years of the great tribulation, Antichrist, instigated by Satan and strengthened by the false prophet, will blaspheme God and make war with the saints and overcome them. Satanic authority will be given to him over every tribe and nation (Rev. 13:4-7; 12:13-17; 2 Thes. 2:3b-4; Dan. 11:36-39; Matt. 24:15).

7. Satan being bound for a thousand years and cast into the abyss

Satan will be bound for a thousand years and cast into the abyss (Rev. 20:1-3). This will take place after Christ deals with Antichrist and his armies.

8. Christ ruling the nations with an iron rod for one thousand years

Christ will rule the nations with an iron rod for one thousand years and will break them in pieces as vessels of pottery are broken in pieces (Rev. 2:27).

9. The burning of the rebellious people and the casting of the devil into the lake of fire

At the end of the millennium, the nations, deceived by the devil, will rebel against Christ, but fire will come down out of heaven and devour them. Then the devil will be cast into the lake of fire (Rev. 20:7-10).

10. The judgment of the great white throne

At the end of the day of the Lord, there will be the judgment of the great white throne (Rev. 20:11-15) by Christ over the dead men, the demons, and probably the fallen angels (2 Pet. 2:4).

E. The heavens and the earth being renewed

Finally, the heavens and the earth will be renewed with intense burning heat to be the new heavens and the new earth for the New Jerusalem (2 Pet. 3:10-13; Rev. 21:1-2). The day of the Lord ends with this burning heat. The heavens and the earth, the old creation, have been polluted and contaminated by Satan's rebellion and by man's fall and therefore need to be renewed.

The day of the Lord with all of its judgments is for the manifestation of Christ. As we study the Bible, we need to realize that revelation in the Bible is centered on Christ, who is the centrality and universality of God's economy. All the judgments of the day of the Lord, including all the calamities, plagues, and woes, have a goal, and this goal is to bring in the manifestation of Christ.

The Content

(1)

Scripture Reading: Joel 1:2-20; 2:1-11

The book of Joel contains three main points. The first main point is the plague of the four kinds of locusts (the nations) or of one kind of locust in four stages. The second main point is the outpouring of the consummated Spirit. This outpouring initiated the church life, which is the content of the age of mystery. The third main point is the restoration not only of Israel but of the entire universe. This restoration will consummate in the new heaven and new earth with the New Jerusalem. In this message we will consider the first of these three main points.

I. The plague of the locusts (the nations)

The plague of the locusts (the nations) is covered in 1:2—2:11.

A. The seriousness of the prophecy

Joel 1:2-4 shows us the seriousness of the prophecy.

1. A message for the elders among the people and for all the inhabitants of the land

The elders among the people should hear this message, and all the inhabitants of the land should give heed to it. They should tell their children about it, their children should tell their children, and their children should tell the next generation (vv. 2-3; Psa. 78:6).

2. The cutting locust, the swarming locust, the licking locust, and the consuming locust

Joel 1:4 says that what the cutting locust has left, the swarming locust has eaten; and what the swarming locust has left, the licking locust has eaten; and what the licking locust has left, the consuming locust has eaten. Four words for locust are used in this verse, probably referring to one kind of locust in various stages of growth. As we will see, this one kind of locust in four stages corresponds to the four sections of the great human image in Daniel 2, to the four beasts in Daniel 7, and to the four horns in Zechariah 1. The cutting locust refers to the Babylonian Empire; the swarming locust, to the Medo-Persian Empire; the licking locust, to the Grecian Empire; and the consuming locust, to the Roman Empire.

B. The coming up of a nation, mighty and without number, against the land of Jehovah

Joel 1:6a speaks of the coming up of a nation, mighty and without number, against the land of Jehovah.

1. Likened to one kind of locust in four stages

The coming of such a nation is likened to one kind of locust in four stages: the cutting locust, the swarming locust, the licking locust, and the consuming locust (v. 4; 2:2, 4-11). The four successive kinds of locusts refer to the nations which devastated Israel in four consecutive empires: Babylon, Medo-Persia, Greece, and Rome.

2. Further likened to the great human image in four sections

This mighty nation is further likened to the great human image in four sections: the golden head — Babylon; the silver breast and arms — Medo-Persia; the bronze abdomen and thighs — Greece; and the iron legs with the feet — Rome (Dan. 2:31-33).

3. Further likened to four beasts

The coming up of a nation, mighty and without number, is further likened to four beasts: a lion, a bear, a leopard, and the one who is the totality of the first three (Dan. 7:2-8; Rev. 13:2a).

4. Likened ultimately to four horns

This nation is likened ultimately to four horns (Zech. 1:18-21). The four horns, the four beasts, the four sections of the great image, and the four kinds of locusts all refer to the same four empires. Throughout human history, in God's dealing with Israel and in God's punishment upon the Gentiles, these four empires have been and still are the center.

5. To devastate the land of Jehovah

The nation mentioned in Joel 1:6a came to devastate the land of Jehovah, devouring and breaking the people into pieces and making the land a desolation (vv. 6b-7a; 2:3; Dan. 7:7; Isa. 10:3; Jer. 25:11). Because of this desolation, there was no food to feed the people and no wine to cheer the people (Joel 1:5, 7, 10-12, 16a, 17), no meal offering and no drink offering for the priests to offer to God in His temple (vv. 9, 13, 16b), and no pasture for the beasts, herds of cattle, and herds of sheep (vv. 18-20).

6. From Nebuchadnezzar, the first king of the Babylonian Empire, to the last Caesar of the Roman Empire

The empires that have devastated the land of Jehovah include the empires from Nebuchadnezzar, the first king of the Babylonian Empire, through the Medo-Persian Empire and the Macedonian and Grecian Empire, to the last Caesar (Antichrist) of the Roman Empire (Dan. 7:2-8; 8:3-14; 11:2-45; Rev. 13:1-18; 17:11-14; 19:19-21). Babylon actually began with Babel, which was founded by Nimrod (Gen. 10:8-10), the first type of Antichrist.

The Bible likens these four empires to locusts. A plague of locusts is terrible. In just one day an entire harvest can be consumed; nothing can stop the devouring locusts. The armies of Babylon, Medo-Persia, Greece, and Rome were like locusts coming to devastate Israel totally, devouring their people, land, fields, produce, food, and drink and cutting off their offerings.

Apparently, these four empires are human like the great human image representing the totality of human government. However, in the sight of God they are beasts. Babylon is the lion; Medo-Persia is the bear; Greece is the leopard; and Rome, being the totality of the first three, is the most wild and devastating beast of all. Ultimately, these four empires are four horns used by Satan to devastate God's chosen people. The prophecies concerning this are now history.

Daniel 7:12 says, "As for the rest of the beasts, their dominion was taken away, but an extension of life was given to them for a season and a time." This indicates that as each empire was defeated, although its dominion was taken away, its culture was adopted by each succeeding empire. Thus each empire continued to live. The culture of Babylon was adopted by Medo-Persia; the culture of Medo-Persia was adopted by Greece; and the culture of Greece was adopted by Rome. From this we see that the Roman Empire inherited the cultures of the three foregoing empires. The dominion of the Roman Empire is over, but its "life," its culture, continues. In a sense, we all are Roman citizens, for we are under the influence of the spirit of the Roman Empire, especially in the matters of politics and law. Today the world's culture is Roman, yet, being an accumulated culture, it contains the cultures of the Babylonians, Persians, and Greeks.

The Bible covers four things: God's chastisement on His elect people, God's punishment of the nations, the manifestation of Christ, and the restoration. These four matters are covered in Joel, a short book of three chapters. First, God sent the locusts to devastate Israel. This was His chastisement for Israel's great evils. Second, this book reveals that God will punish and judge the Gentile nations. Third, Joel speaks concerning the outpouring of the processed, consummated, compound Spirit, the Spirit of God compounded with Christ's humanity, Christ's death and its effectiveness, and Christ's resurrection with its power. This is the Holy Spirit who was poured out on the day of Pentecost, and this Spirit is the consummated Christ for the manifestation of Christ. This manifestation began with the incarnation of Christ and has been confirmed and strengthened by the outpouring of the Spirit because, through that outpouring, the individual Christ became the corporate Christ, initiating the church life and the church age. The church is the great mystery of godliness, God manifested in the flesh (1 Tim. 3:15-16). Hence, we are the manifestation of Christ. Now we are awaiting the fourth matter revealed in the book of Joel — the glorious day of restoration, which will consummate in the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and new earth. This is the revelation of the Bible, and this is the history of the universe.

The four empires signified by the locusts are very worldly, but they are used by God's Craftsman (Christ — Dan. 2:34-35) as His instrument to chastise Israel and punish the nations. In this way God is accomplishing whatever is needed for Christ to be manifested in full, that the entire universe may be fully restored.

The Content

(2)

Scripture Reading: Joel 2:12-32; 3:1-21

Joel is a short book of three chapters, but it covers human history from 606 B.C. to the millennium. A major revelation in Joel is that God has raised up four empires symbolized by four kinds of locusts, beginning with Babylon and continuing with Medo-Persia, Greece, and the Roman Empire, to devastate the one small nation of Israel, God's elect. Today this devastation is still going on. Along the way, while such a history was proceeding, God poured out Himself as the incarnated, crucified, resurrected, and ascended One, the processed and consummated Triune God as the Spirit, upon the believers of Christ. That outpouring produced the church and began the age of mystery. Everything concerning the church is a mystery, and this mystery is the manifestation of Christ. Now we are here in the church doing things in a mysterious way to usher in the final appearing of Christ to bring in the age of restoration, the thousand-year kingdom, which is the prelude to the new heaven and the new earth with the New Jerusalem. This is the revelation in the book of Joel.

Let us now go on to consider further the content of Joel in 2:12—3:21. In this portion we have the turn of Jehovah to His elect, Israel (2:12-32), the judgment of Christ upon the nations (3:1-15), and the victory of Christ with His overcomers over the nations and His reign among Israel in the age of restoration (3:9-13, 16-21).

II. The turn of Jehovah to His elect, Israel

A. Wanting them to turn to Jehovah their God

Jehovah wanted His elect to turn to Him. Verses 12 through 17 of chapter two reveal in what way they should return to their God.

1. With all their heart

Jehovah wanted His elect to turn to Him with all their heart (v. 12a).

2. With fasting, weeping, and mourning

He wanted them to turn to Him also with fasting, weeping, and mourning (v. 12b).

3. Rending their hearts and not their garments

In returning to their God, Jehovah's elect should rend their hearts and not their garments (v. 13). They should do this so that God would turn, repent, and leave a blessing behind Him — a meal offering and a drink offering (v. 14).

The meal offering and the drink offering are blessings to Israel. When Nebuchadnezzar destroyed Jerusalem and the temple, Israel lost the place appointed by God where they could offer their offerings to God (Deut. 12:5-6). Also, God's army of locusts destroyed the produce of the land, leaving no grain to make a meal offering and no grapes to make wine for the drink offering. Thus, Israel lost both the ground and the materials to offer the meal offering to feed God and the drink offering to cheer God. Today both God and Israel are still suffering the loss of this blessing.

4. Blowing a trumpet in Zion

In Joel 2:15a Jehovah says, "Blow a trumpet in Zion." To blow a trumpet is to make a declaration in a triumphant spirit.

5. Sanctifying a fast

Verse 15b goes on to say, "Sanctify a fast." This fast was not to be common; rather, it was to be sanctified, separated for God.

6. Calling a solemn assembly

Jehovah also wanted His elect to call a solemn assembly: gathering the people, assembling the elders, and letting the bridegroom go forth from his chamber and the bride from her canopy (vv. 15c-16). Such an assembly is a great blessing, something that should not be missed.

7. Letting the priests weep between the porch and the altar

Verse 17 says, "Let the priests, the ministers of Jehovah, / Weep between the porch and the altar, / And let them say, / Look with pity, O Jehovah, upon Your people; / And do not give Your inheritance over to reproach, / That the nations should rule over them. / Why should they say among the nations, / Where is their God?" The porch and the altar were outside the temple, and between the porch and the altar the priests were to weep for Israel's having lost the blessing. Nevertheless, the people, having been brought back to God, had the ground to enjoy the blessing. They had the altar, ordained by God, where they could offer what God desired for His satisfaction.

B. Desiring to bless His own land

In verses 18 through 27 we see that God desires to bless His own land. The holy land, a particular area of land, is God's land.

1. With the rich produce of the land

God desires to bless His own land with the rich produce of the land (vv. 19, 21-22, 25-27).

2. By the rains

God desires to bless His land also by the rains: the former rain and the latter rain (v. 23).

3. By driving away from the people the enemies sent by God as His great army

Finally, God desires to bless His land by driving away from the peoples the enemies sent by Him as the swarming locusts, the licking locusts, the consuming locusts, and the cutting locusts as His great army (vv. 20, 25).

C. Willing to save them

Verses 28 through 32 reveal that God is willing to save His elect, Israel.

1. By pouring out His Spirit upon them

Jehovah is willing to save Israel by pouring out His Spirit (as the former rain) upon them (vv. 28-29). This prophecy was fulfilled as a foretaste on the day of Pentecost (Acts 2:1-4, 16-21), and it will be fulfilled as a full taste before the great tribulation for the salvation and regeneration of many of the returned Israelites. This outpouring is different from the outpouring of the Spirit on the last day of the tribulation (Zech. 12:10) for the salvation of the remnant of the Jews under Antichrist's besieging.

The Spirit poured out on the day of Pentecost was the Spirit of God compounded with Christ's humanity, death, resurrection, and ascension. This compounded Spirit who has been poured out is the realization of Christ and the consummation of the Triune God. God poured Himself upon those who called on the name of the Lord. This outpouring produced the church. Formerly, there were only the Jews and the Gentiles, but now there is the church as a third entity (1 Cor. 10:32). The church is mysterious, for it is in the church that Christ is manifested.

The outpouring of the consummated Spirit is Christ's coming. Christ came through incarnation. Eventually, He died and was resurrected, and, in a sense, He went away. But by the outpouring of the Spirit He came back to be manifested. By this outpouring all the disciples and saved ones on the day of Pentecost became parts of the corporate Christ. The individual Christ has thus become the corporate Christ, the enlarged, increased Christ, which is the church as the manifestation of God in the flesh (1 Tim. 3:15-16).

From what we have covered so far in this life-study of Joel, we can see that this book deals with world history. Our text for the study of history is the Bible, in particular the short book of Joel. In this book we see the nations as the locusts and the devastation of Israel by these locusts. Here we also see a great outpouring of the Spirit as the consummated Triune God upon those Jews who call upon the name of Jehovah and who thus are regenerated to become part of the church for the manifestation of Christ.

2. Through their calling on the name of Jehovah

Joel 2:32 indicates that God's elect people will be saved through their calling on the name of Jehovah. The equivalent of this in the New Testament is calling on the name of the Lord Jesus.

3. Accompanied by the natural calamities of the sixth seal and the first four trumpets

God's saving of Israel by pouring out His Spirit upon them will be accompanied by the natural calamities of the sixth seal and the first four trumpets (Rev. 6:12-17; 8:7-12) on the heavens, the sun, the moon, the stars, and the earth (Joel 2:30-31a) as a prelude to the great tribulation (Matt. 24:21).

4. Before the fifth trumpet, the first of the three woes

The second outpouring of the Spirit for the saving of the returned Jews will take place before the fifth trumpet, the first of the three woes (Rev. 8:13—9:19; 11:14; 15:5—16:21), which are the major structure of the great tribulation, in the great and terrible day of Jehovah (Joel 2:31b). However, many of the returned Jews will not believe but will continue to be stubborn. Eventually, during the tribulation, Jerusalem will be surrounded by the Gentile armies under Antichrist, whose intention will be to destroy Israel entirely. At that juncture the Lord Jesus Christ will descend with His overcomers. Furthermore, according to Zechariah 12, at that time the consummated Spirit will again be poured out, and the remnant of the children of Israel will be saved.

Thus, there are three outpourings of the Holy Spirit: first, the outpouring on the day of Pentecost; second, the outpouring just before the great tribulation upon the Jews; and third, the outpouring upon the besieged Jews, who will have no way to escape the persecution of Antichrist. These three outpourings work together for the salvation of Israel.

III. The judgment of Christ upon the nations

Joel 3:1-15 speaks concerning the judgment of Christ upon the nations — the judgment upon the living (Acts 10:42; 17:31).

A. At the valley of Jehoshaphat

This judgment will take place at the valley of Jehoshaphat, which is the valley of decision (Joel 3:2, 12, 14).

B. To recompense the nations' mistreatment of Israel during the great tribulation

The purpose of Christ's judgment upon the living will be to recompense the nations' mistreatment of Israel during the great tribulation (vv. 2b-8; Rev. 12:17; 13:7, 10; Matt. 25:41-46a). After Christ casts Antichrist and the false prophet into the lake of fire, He will set up His throne in Jerusalem, and all the living ones as the goats and the sheep will be gathered before Him to be judged by Him. The goats will be the evil ones, those who persecuted the Jews, and the sheep will be the good ones, those who helped the persecuted Jews during the tribulation.

IV. The victory of Christ with His overcomers over the nations and His reign among Israel in the age of restoration

Finally, Joel speaks regarding the victory of Christ with His overcomers over the nations and His reign among Israel in the age of restoration (3:9-13, 16-21).

A. Christ with His overcomers defeating Antichrist and his armies at Armageddon

First, according to verses 9 through 13, Christ with His overcomers (Rev. 17:14; 19:11-14) as the mighty ones will defeat Antichrist and his armies (the nations) at Armageddon.

B. Christ reigning among Israel on the holy mountain of Zion within Jerusalem

After the defeat of Antichrist, Christ will reign among Israel on the holy mountain of Zion within Jerusalem (Joel 3:16a, 17, 21b).

C. Christ being a shelter and a stronghold to the children of Israel

As Christ reigns in Jerusalem, He will be a shelter and a stronghold to the children of Israel (v. 16b). Because of this, no one will be able to damage Israel anymore.

D. In the restoration

Christ's reign among Israel on the holy mountain of Zion within Jerusalem will be in the restoration (v. 18; Matt. 19:28).

1. The mountains dropping down fresh wine and the hills flowing with milk

Joel 3:18a tells us that in the restoration the mountains will drop down fresh wine, and the hills will flow with milk. This indicates how rich the situation will be.

2. All the waterways of Judah flowing with water

In the restoration there will be no shortage of water, for all the waterways of Judah will flow with water (v. 18b). Wherever there is a waterway, there will be a river full of water.

3. A fountain going forth from the house of Jehovah to water the land

A fountain will go forth from the house of Jehovah, the temple, to water the entire holy land (v. 18c). This points to the situation in the New Jerusalem, where a river will flow out of the throne of God and of the Lamb to water the holy city.

E. All the surrounding enemies of Israel being punished

Joel 3:19-21a tells us that all the surrounding enemies of Israel will be punished. Therefore, the nations will be punished, Israel will be restored, and Christ will be manifested. This will be a prelude to the new heaven and new earth with the New Jerusalem.

The Controlling Prophecy of the Four Locusts in the Book of Joel

Scripture Reading: Joel 1:4; 2:28-32; 3:9-21

In this message I have the burden to give a further word on the prophecy concerning the four kinds of locusts in the book of Joel.

The difference between Daniel and Joel

In the interpretation of the prophecies of the Bible, Joel's prophecy is more controlling than Daniel's. It is true to say that Daniel's prophecy is the controlling factor for us to understand and interpret the prophecies in the Bible. However, the controlling factors in Daniel are on the surface, whereas the factors in Joel are hidden, concealed, in a mysterious way. For this reason, if we would understand the book of Joel, we must have insight.

The four kinds of locusts denoting the four sections of human government

The first factor in Joel is the locusts in four stages: the cutting locust, symbolizing Babylon; the swarming locust, symbolizing Medo-Persia; the licking locust, symbolizing Greece; and the consuming locust, symbolizing the Roman Empire (1:4). These four kinds of locusts denote the four sections of the entire human government on earth signified by the great human image in Daniel 2. After these four sections of human government, which will end with Antichrist, the last Caesar of the Roman Empire, human government will be brought to an end.

The four kinds of locusts consuming the nation of Israel

These four kinds of locusts are related to the small nation of Israel. In a sense, God sent the four sections of the human government as locusts to consume Israel.

The four kinds of locusts, corresponding to the four sections of human government, will occupy a long period of time in human history, from the time of Nebuchadnezzar to the time of Antichrist. This period will last for at least twenty-seven centuries. Between the times of Nebuchadnezzar and Antichrist, there will be a long time in which the Jews will have no nation, no kings, no priests, no prophets, and no temple as the God-ordained center where they can worship God. Today the Jews are still being consumed by the locusts of the human, Gentile government.

Through the roman locusts God's redemption and the preaching of the gospel being carried out

The final stage of God's sending of the locusts is the Roman Empire. While the Roman Empire was chastising rebellious Israel, God did something silently and mysteriously. God used the Roman Empire to keep the region around the Mediterranean Sea — the center of human habitation — in a peaceful order. Highways were built, shipping routes were established on the sea, and a common language, Greek, was spoken by all the peoples. It was at that time that God came to be incarnated by being born of a virgin in a small city, Bethlehem, and eventually lived in Nazareth. For thirty-three and a half years the God of everlasting love lived on the earth in His humanity as a man. After this He went to the cross and died the death of a criminal under the Roman form of capital punishment. Although the worldlings did not realize it, Christ died a vicarious, all-inclusive death. After three days He resurrected. On the same day, in the morning of His resurrection, He ascended to the Father and descended again to the earth to meet with His disciples. Forty days later, in the presence of His disciples, He ascended to the heavens. After ten more days, on the day of Pentecost, He came down again by being poured out as the Spirit upon three thousand of His believers, making each of the three thousand the same as He is in life and nature. The issue of that outpouring of the Spirit was a corporate Christ, which is the manifestation of Christ.

From this we see that it was through the Roman locusts that both God's redemption and the preaching of the gospel were carried out. First, the gospel was spread throughout the Roman Empire and then, as a result of Roman imperialism, to other parts of the world. The Romans invented imperialism, and all the Western powers are parts of the Roman Empire. After Britain defeated Spain to become the world power, for more than two centuries the gospel was spread to every corner of the earth through Roman imperialism.

The three things that are taking place on earth today

Today three things are taking place on earth: the consuming by the Roman locusts, the suffering of Israel, and the manifestation of Christ. We are joined neither to the consuming of the Roman locusts nor to the suffering of Israel but to the manifestation of Christ. Little of Christ is manifested in the Roman Catholic Church and in the denominations, but Christ is manifested in His recovery. Today we are in the line in which Christ is being manifested. The line of the manifestation of Christ will eventually bring us into the fuller manifestation of Christ in the age of restoration. This fuller manifestation of Christ will consummate in the fullest manifestation of Christ in the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and new earth. This is the proper eschatology. This is the best, the clearest, and the most inclusive eschatology.

God and the Bible both being real

God is real. If God were not real, there could not be such a book as the Bible. The Bible tells us beforehand concerning world history. The Bible is the only book that predicts human history so accurately and all-inclusively. Therefore, we believe not only that our God is real but also that the Bible is real.

The need for a clear view concerning three matters

We all need to have a clear view of the age in which we are living, of where we are, and of what our goal should be.

The present age

We are living in an age, the continuation of the preceding ages, in which our God is still moving. He is working among the Jews and by the nations to perform His economy in the building up of the organism of the Body of Christ.

Where we are

We need to see that today we, the believers in Christ, are in the Body of Christ. We all are members of the Body of Christ, which is the organism of the Triune God. As members of the Body, we should aspire to be overcomers, the mighty ones (Joel 3:11) who will return with Christ to deal with Antichrist at the battle of Armageddon and who will be His co-kings in the millennium.

Our goal as members of the Body of Christ

Furthermore, we should be clear concerning our goal as members of the Body. Our goal is to enlarge the manifestation of Christ intrinsically. We do not care for a mere outward enlargement. We do not appreciate a good outward appearance, and we do not want any kind of façade. On the contrary, we desire to see the intrinsic enlargement of the manifestation of Christ in the Spirit of the processed Triune God and by the life of our Father, the eternal, almighty divine Being.

Taking the overcoming way

I hope that we all will take not the ordinary Christian way but the overcoming way to be the mighty ones who can match the unique mighty One. Christ is now on the throne in the heavens, waiting for us to be perfected and matured. Eventually the time will be ripe for Him to come back to deal with the nations, to save the remnant of Israel, and to complete God's economy with us. Then the age of restoration will be ushered in. That age will consummate in the New Jerusalem as the ultimate consummation of God's expression in Christ.

Message 5

The Four Factors in the Book of Joel

Scripture Reading: Joel 1:4; 2:28-32; 3:16-21

In this message I would like to give a further word on the four factors, the four main principles, in the book of Joel.

The first factor — the consuming of the locusts

The first factor, or principle, is the consuming of the locusts, the consuming factor. “What the cutting locust has left, the swarming locust has eaten; / And what the swarming locust has left, the licking locust has eaten; / And what the licking locust has left, the consuming locust has eaten” (1:4). These locusts denote the human government which has been existing for twenty-seven hundred years and which continues to exist. The governments of the nations have been and are still being used by God to consume Israel. On earth today there is such a consuming factor involving the nations.

The second factor — the suffering of Israel

The second factor, the second principle, is the suffering factor, the suffering of Israel under the locusts. Israel has been suffering the consuming of the locusts for almost twenty-seven centuries. As we consider Israel’s suffering, we may wonder why God has allowed it to last so long. We may question why God has permitted His elect to suffer under the consuming locusts. On the one hand, God allows this suffering to continue; on the other hand, He does not allow Israel to be utterly consumed. Israel is the only nation that has suffered the consuming of the locusts for such a long time. Nevertheless, Israel continues to endure and to last.

These two factors — the consuming factor involving the nations in four stages and the suffering factor involving Israel — have been present for a major part of human history. Many books have been written about world history, but these books do not touch these factors, these principles, as we are doing here.

God’s purpose concerning the suffering factor

We come now to the crucial matter of God’s purpose concerning the suffering factor. The suffering factor is the factor which produced the incarnation. Through incarnation the almighty, eternal, infinite God was brought into humanity and mingled with humanity. Nothing, not even the creation of the universe, could be greater than this! God’s purpose in allowing Israel to suffer under the locusts was to bring forth a couple, Mary and Joseph, so that God could be born in man, of man, and out of man to become no longer only God but a God-man. Hence, the suffering factor was the factor to consummate the divine incarnation; the suffering of the Jews was the factor to produce the incarnation. As a result of God’s entering into humanity and His mingling with humanity, there is now a unique person — Jesus — who is both the complete God and a perfect man. God became a man, the man Jesus, and lived on this earth, making His home in Nazareth for thirty years. Surely this is the greatest miracle in the entire universe!

God’s use of the consuming factor

We have seen that Israel was used by God through so much suffering for the purpose that God could be born out of man to be a God-man. Now we need to see how God has used the consuming factor and is still using this factor.

It is the first factor, the consuming factor, that has afforded all the necessary facilities in the environment for the carrying out of God's purpose. The Roman Empire, the aggregate of the four empires, afforded everything necessary for the incarnated God to live and move and work on earth. Furthermore, the Roman Empire afforded the means for Christ to be crucified, for it had the governmental authority, prepared a cross, and even provided the soldiers to crucify the Lord Jesus.

Both the consuming factor and the suffering factor have been useful to God. The Jews had lost their nation and had been scattered everywhere, wandering for centuries. Humanly speaking, that was a tragedy. But on the day of Pentecost, after God had consummated His long process of incarnation, human living, crucifixion, resurrection, and ascension, He needed to pour Himself out upon the entire human race, not only upon one people but upon all peoples. For this outpouring a particular occasion was required, and the Roman Empire made it possible. First, the Roman Empire had scattered the Jews among all the peoples. Then, on exactly the right day, when the time was ripe, the Roman Empire provided the way for the scattered people to come back to Jerusalem to enjoy the feast. At that joyful time, God suddenly came down upon the people. From this we see that through the means of the suffering one, Israel, and by all the facilities provided by the consuming locust, the Roman government, God poured Himself out upon all flesh. Now we, as the church, are the manifestation of Christ, produced by the outpouring of the processed and consummated Triune God upon all flesh.

Today's locusts are also useful to God and to us, the members of the church, the Body of Christ. Because of the locusts we have such things as the telephone, the microphone, the recorder, the airplane, the computer, and the fax machine. Because of the locusts we in the United States enjoy the freedom of speech and the freedom to meet together as the church. The facilities provided by the locusts also save us a great deal of time. Therefore, we are thankful for the "locust" government and for the "locust" telephone and computer companies. In a very real sense, all the locusts are working for us. The millions of locusts swarming on earth today are serving us so that we may be here for the manifestation of Christ.

The third factor — the beneficiaries

The consuming of the locusts and the suffering of Israel are both for us. This means that we in the church life today are the beneficiaries of both the Jews and the nations. This is the third factor, the third principle. Paul says that all things work together for good for us (Rom. 8:28). Hence, we are the third factor — the beneficiaries. As the beneficiaries, we should thank the Lord for all that He has done for us through the consuming of the locusts and the suffering of the Jews.

The fourth factor — the principle of restoration

The fourth factor in the book of Joel is the principle of restoration. In the future there will be an actual, practical, and real restoration, but today we, the third factor, are experiencing the restoration, the fourth factor, as we participate in and enjoy the manifestation of Christ, which has come through the first two factors, the consuming of the locusts and the suffering of Israel.

The Universal History According to God's Economy—the Divine History within the Human History

Scripture Reading: Joel 1:4; 2:28-29; 3:11-21

In Joel we see the history of God, of man, and of God's economy. It was according to God's economy that the four kinds of locusts were raised up to consume Israel for so many years in order that He could fulfill His economy by being incarnated into humanity through Israel. Then with the help of the Roman Empire, Christ lived on earth, was crucified, and was resurrected to be enlarged, to produce the church. All of this was through these two factors — the consuming locusts and the suffering Israel — that God could fulfill His economy to have an expression, the organic Body of Christ. We are this Body, this expression. This is the universal history according to God's economy. In this message I would like to give a further word on this universal history.

Two histories — the history of man and the history of God

We should not think that man has a history but that God does not have a history. In this universe there are two histories: the history of man, the human history, and the history of God, the divine history. We may liken the history of man to the shell of a walnut and the history of God to the kernel within the shell. In the Minor Prophets the "shell" is clearly defined, and the "kernel" is revealed in some detail. Unfortunately, however, most readers of the Bible pay attention only to the shell and not to the kernel.

The shell, the history of man, is easily seen. In Daniel 2 this history is signified by a great human image, with the four sections of this image corresponding respectively to the Babylonian Empire, the Medo-Persian Empire, the Grecian Empire, and the Roman Empire. Although it is easy for us to see the shell, which is something outward and physical, we must have a kind of intrinsic insight in order to see the kernel within the shell, to know the divine history within the human history.

The divine history within the human history

God's intention in His economy

If we would know the divine history that takes place within the human history, we first need to realize that the Triune God is eternal. For God to be eternal means that with Him there is no beginning. Within Himself, this eternal One made an economy. According to His economy, God wants to work Himself into man to be one with man, to be man's life, life supply, and everything, and to have man as His expression. God's intention in His economy is thus to have a corporate entity, composed of God and man, to be His expression for eternity. This divine history began with the eternal God and His economy.

The continuation of the divine history

Christ's incarnation and human living

The divine history continued with the incarnation and human living of Christ. One day the very God who created the universe became incarnated, being conceived of the Holy Spirit within the womb of a human virgin and then born of this virgin to be the God-man, the One who is the complete God and a perfect man. It is marvelous that God became a man named Jesus and that this man lived in Nazareth, working as a carpenter, until the age of thirty. Christ's incarnation and His human living both are parts of the divine history, the history of God within the history of man.

Christ's crucifixion and resurrection

At the end of His life and ministry on earth, the Lord Jesus went willingly to the cross. His crucifixion was a vicarious death, an all-inclusive death which terminated the old creation and solved all problems. His death ushered Him into resurrection. On the one hand, in His resurrection He was begotten to be the firstborn Son of God (Acts 13:33; Rom. 1:4; 8:29). On the other hand, in and through His resurrection He became the life-giving Spirit (1 Cor. 15:45b).

Furthermore, through Christ's resurrection millions were begotten, regenerated, by God (1 Pet. 1:3) to be sons of God and to be members of the Body of Christ, the church. The Christ who was incarnated, crucified, and resurrected, the Christ who ascended to the heavens and then descended as the Spirit, has produced the church as the corporate expression of the Triune God. The church today is the enlargement of the manifestation of Christ. Thus, the church also is part of the divine history, the intrinsic history of the divine mystery within the outward, human history. This part of God's history has lasted for more than nineteen hundred years, and it is still going on.

Christ's coming back, the kingdom, and the New Jerusalem

At the end of this part of the divine history, Christ will come back, descending with His overcomers as His army (Joel 3:11) to defeat Antichrist and his army. There will be the meeting of two figures — Antichrist, a figure in the outward, human history, and Christ with His overcomers, the Figure in the intrinsic, divine history. The Figure in the divine history will defeat the figure in the human history and then cast him into the lake of fire (Rev. 19:20). Following this, the thousand-year kingdom will come. Eventually, this kingdom will consummate in the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and new earth. The New Jerusalem will be the ultimate, the consummate, step of God's history.

The need for a clear view of the two histories

We need to have a clear view of these two histories — the physical human history and the mysterious divine history — and I hope that we all will have such a view. The history of man, the history of the world, is outward. The divine history, the history of God in and with humanity, is inward. This history is a matter of the divine mystery of the Triune God in humanity.

Born in the human history and reborn in the divine history to live in the divine history in the church life

We all were born in the human history, but we have been reborn, regenerated, in the divine history. Now we need to ask ourselves this question: Are we living in the divine history, or are we living merely in the human history? If our living is in the world, we are living in the human history. But if we are living in the church, we are living in the divine history. In the church life God's history is our history. Now two parties — God and we — have one history, the divine history. This is the church life.

With the divine history there is the new creation — the new man with a new heart, a new spirit, a new life, a new nature, a new history, and a new consummation. We praise the Lord that we are in the divine history, experiencing and enjoying the mysterious, divine things.

The History with Man and the History of God in Man

Scripture Reading: Joel 1:4; 2:28-29; 3:11-21

The Bible is a wonderful book. Because the Bible is wonderful, it is mysterious. Although a great many people have read and continue to read the Bible, few know what the Bible talks about. The Bible has much to say about God, Christ, Israel, and many other things, but what does the Bible actually talk about? If we would answer this question, we need to study the Minor Prophets.

The Minor Prophets — a key to understanding the Bible

The Minor Prophets are a key to understanding the Bible. In our study of the Minor Prophets, we have emphasized four points: God's chastisement of Israel, God's punishment upon the nations, the manifestation of Christ, and the restoration of all things. Through God's chastisement of Israel and His punishment upon the nations, the manifestation of Christ is brought forth, and the manifestation of Christ will bring in the restoration. This restoration will include not only Israel but the whole human race, the earth, and the entire universe. The new heaven and new earth with the New Jerusalem will be the eternal restoration of all things. These four matters are revealed in the Bible, in particular in the Minor Prophets.

The Bible being the history of God in two portions

The Bible may be considered the history of God. If we human beings have a history, not only as a race but even as individuals, then surely the unique, universal, and wonderful person of God must also have a history. Where do we find the history of God? God's history, the divine history, is recorded in the Bible.

God's history is of two portions — the history of God with man, found in the Old Testament, and the history of God in man, found in the New Testament. In the Old Testament God's history was a history with man. In the New Testament God's history is a history in man, for this history involves God's being one with man. Therefore, the history of God in the New Testament is a divine history in humanity.

The history of God with man

God created man according to Himself, that is, in His image and according to His likeness (Gen. 1:26-27). We may say that the man created in God's image was a "photograph" of God. As a photograph of a person shows us something concerning that person himself to a certain degree, so the man created by God as a photograph of God can show forth God only to a limited extent. After God created man, He was with man, but He was still outside of man. Hence, in the Old Testament we see God not in man or one with man but simply with man. In Genesis, Exodus, the Psalms, and the entire Old Testament, God was with man but not yet in man and not yet one with man.

The Old Testament does not speak mainly concerning man; rather, it speaks mainly concerning God. God has the primary role, and man has the subordinate role. The history in the Old Testament, therefore, is God's history, God's history with man.

The history of God in man

God's history in the New Testament is very different. Beginning with the first chapter of Matthew and continuing to the last chapter of Revelation, we have God coming into man and being one with man. The New Testament reveals that God is now in man and one with man. Thus, God's history in the New Testament is the history of God in man.

The incarnation accomplishing two things

Bringing God into man

Regarding the history of God in man, the incarnation of Christ accomplished two things. First, the incarnation brought God into man. Before the incarnation, as the Old Testament reveals, God was merely with man; He was outside of man. But by incarnation God entered into man, and from that time onward the history of God was different. Whereas in the past God was with man, and His history was a history with man, now God was in man, and His history began to be a history in man.

Making God one with man

Second, the incarnation made God one with man. As a result of the incarnation, there was a wonderful person — a person who is the mingling of God with man. This person, Jesus, is not only God, and He is not merely a man. He is the complete God and the perfect man. Further, He is not only God in man — He is God mingled with man.

From this we see that the incarnation was an unprecedented event. Prior to the incarnation, there was not such a person, a person who is both God and man. But now, as a result of the incarnation, there is a wonderful person who is the mingling of God with man.

Our involvement with the God-man

As believers, we all have become involved with this wonderful person, this One who is both God and man. A verse which speaks of this involvement is Revelation 22:17a, which says, “The Spirit and the bride say, Come!” The Spirit is the consummated Triune God, and the bride is the transformed tripartite man. As this verse reveals, these two, the Spirit and the bride, will be married, joined to become one entity, one corporate person. This is a strong indication that, in the New Testament, God is in man and is one with man. The New Jerusalem is a marvelous sign demonstrating how God is in man and is one with man.

Man not taking God’s way

The history of God with man and of God in man is not a simple matter. God was with man with the intention of coming into man and being one with man. Man was created by God for this purpose. But although God had such a purpose in creating man, man has another, subtle, purpose, and these two purposes do not agree. God has His way, and man has his way. Because of this, even when man cooperates with God, he does this not by God’s way but by his own way. Thus, there are two lines — God’s line and man’s line. God wants to come into man and to be one with man. Man, however, does not take God’s way but insists on his own way. This insistence has caused, and continues to cause, great failure. As a result, in the sight of God man has become sinful, corrupt, and abominable.

God coming in to chastise His chosen people and to punish the nations

Because man, including Israel, has taken his own way and has become sinful and corrupt, God comes in to chastise Israel, His chosen people, and to punish the nations. When God chastises His people Israel, He has no intention of utterly destroying them. On the one hand, God chastises Israel; on the other hand, He has promised not to destroy them completely.

In order to chastise Israel God needs a “rod,” a means of discipline, and this rod is the nations. In Joel 1:4 the nations are likened to locusts in four stages: the cutting locust (the Babylonian Empire), the swarming locust (the Medo-Persian Empire), the licking locust (the Macedonian- Grecian Empire), and the consuming locust (the Roman Empire). Of these four kinds of locusts — Babylonian, Persian, Greek, and Roman — the Roman locusts are still with us today.

Although God allows the locusts to cut, swarm, lick, and consume, He does not permit them to destroy His people utterly. Whenever the locusts have gone too far, acting without regard for justice, God has come in to punish them. Whereas God uses the nations to chastise Israel, He also punishes the nations for going too far.

God’s chastisement of Israel and His punishment of the nations affording a way for Christ to be manifested for the restoration of the fallen universe

God’s chastisement of Israel and His punishment of the nations affords a way for Christ to be manifested. Thus, the Minor Prophets speak not only of the chastisement of Israel and the punishment of the nations but also of the issue of this chastisement and punishment — the manifestation of Christ.

The manifestation of Christ has a goal, and this goal is to restore the fallen universe. The fall of the universe was caused by two rebellions. The first rebellion was the rebellion of Satan and the angels who followed him; the second was the rebellion of man. These two rebellions — the angelic and the human — defiled and polluted the universe, so the God-created universe needs a restoration.

This restoration can be brought in only through the manifestation of Christ. Christ’s manifestation implies His incarnation, redemption, and many other matters. The manifestation of Christ has been going on for a long time, and it will continue until the fallen universe has been fully restored. Eventually, in the consummation of the restoration, there will be the new heaven and new earth with the New Jerusalem as the center. In the New Jerusalem we all will enjoy Christ and express Christ for eternity. This is the history of God with man and in man revealed in the Bible.

The lesson for us today

Our failure

The history of God in the Bible provides a lesson for us today. God created us with the intention to gain us so that He could come into us and be one with us. However, either we do not care for God or we care for God according to our own way. The result is always total failure. Paul confessed his failure when he said, “Wretched man that I am!” (Rom. 7:24a).

Our need for God’s chastisement

Because we are a failure and because our situation is wretched, terrible, and miserable, we need God’s chastisement. For this reason, our human life as Christians is a life of chastisement through the sufferings caused by different kinds of “locusts.” Our husband or wife, our children, our job, our desire for higher education, our attempts to make more money — all these are locusts that cut us, swarm over us, lick us, and consume us. These “locusts” make our life a life of suffering and our days, days of God’s chastisement. The goal, the purpose, of this chastisement is that Christ would be manifested in us for the restoration of the universe. Eventually, the manifestation of Christ that is the issue of suffering and chastisement will consummate in the restoration of the entire universe.